PMP CERTIFICATION COURSE

Student Reference Resource Guide

SECTION 1

PMP Overview & PMBOK 8 Intro

All Lectures Covered

PMBOK Guide 8th Edition

2026 ECO

Section Overview

Section 1 of this course, **Introduction**, establishes the foundation for the entire PMP journey. It opens by explaining why the PMP credential matters, how to become eligible for it, and exactly what the 2026 PMP exam looks like — its domains, weightings, timing, and question formats.

The section then explains how the PMBOK Guide 8th Edition differs from the 7th Edition, before pivoting to the modern project manager mindset PMBOK 8 asks every practitioner to adopt: stewardship, systems thinking, value delivery, adaptability, collaboration, and ethical reasoning.

From there, the section builds the vocabulary and structures used throughout the rest of the course and the exam: business value (tangible and intangible), the **Value Delivery System**, the project manager's competencies and responsibilities, the project-program-portfolio hierarchy, organizational structures, the four project life cycles plus hybrid approaches, organizational and project governance, the drivers behind project initiation, and where operations and project management intersect.

This guide covers all seventeen lectures of Section 1. Each lecture follows the same five-part structure: an Overview that frames the topic, Key Concepts with detailed bullets, Key Terms with precise definitions, Exam Tips that translate the lecture into scoring strategies, and a Knowledge Check that lets you verify your understanding. The Appendix at the end provides a quick reference summary, an organizational-structure authority comparison table, a Section 1 study checklist, and an exam cheat sheet for last-minute review.

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Welcome to the PMP Course: Your Journey to Certification

Overview

This opening lecture frames the PMP credential as the global gold standard in project management and sets expectations for the course itself. The Project Management Institute (PMI) issues the PMP to certify that a candidate has the education, experience, and judgment to lead projects successfully — and PMP holders consistently report stronger salaries and career mobility than their non-certified peers.

The course is built on the two newest standards a candidate must master: the PMBOK Guide 8th Edition and the 2026 PMP Examination Content Outline (ECO). It is delivered as 432 short, focused lectures across seven major sections — a micro-learning structure chosen deliberately to boost retention and fit around a working professional's schedule.

The lecture closes with a call to active learning: treat exam preparation itself as a project, with a plan, dedicated study time, and consistent daily execution rather than last-minute cramming.

Key Concepts

- PMP = Project Management Professional, issued by PMI; the most globally recognized project management credential.
- The course is built on PMBOK Guide 8th Edition and the 2026 PMP Examination Content Outline (ECO).
- The 2026 exam is organized around three domains: People, Process, and Business Environment.
- A dedicated section on AI and Digital Integration reflects PMBOK 8's emphasis on emerging technology.
- Course structure: 7 major sections, 432 lectures, each roughly 4-6 minutes — a micro-learning design intended to improve retention.
- Active learning strategy: take notes, pause to reflect, use knowledge checks, and study consistently rather than cramming.
- Treat PMP preparation itself as a project — it needs a plan, resources, and disciplined execution.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition

PMP	Project Management Professional — PMI's flagship certification recognizing the experience, education, and competency to lead and direct projects.
PMI	Project Management Institute — the global professional association that develops and administers the PMBOK Guide and the PMP certification.
PMBOK Guide	A Guide to the Project Management Body of Knowledge — PMI's foundational standard describing project management practice; now in its 8th Edition.
ECO	Examination Content Outline — PMI's official document defining the domains, tasks, and weightings tested on the PMP exam (2026 version used in this course).
Micro-learning	An instructional design approach that breaks content into short, focused lessons to improve retention and fit flexible schedules.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. The exam is not a memorization test of PMBOK terminology alone — it tests a value-delivery mindset. Keep that lens on every lecture in this course.
2. Know the three exam domains by name (People, Process, Business Environment) from lecture one — they organize the entire rest of the course and the exam blueprint.
3. Expect AI and Digital Integration content to appear across scenario questions, not just in a single isolated section.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What organization issues the PMP certification, and what two standards is this course built on?
2. Name the three domains of the 2026 PMP exam.
3. Why does the course use a micro-learning (short-lecture) structure, and how should you use active learning to prepare?

PMP Certification Requirements: Eligibility and Application Process

Overview

Before anyone can sit the PMP exam, PMI requires proof of both project management education and real project leadership experience. This lecture walks through the two eligibility pillars, the sliding experience scale tied to academic background, the GAC-accredited-degree shortcut, and the practical mechanics of documenting experience and submitting an application.

Eligibility is not just a formality — PMI's audit process exists specifically to verify that these requirements were met honestly, so understanding the rules in detail protects you from application delays or rejected audits.

Key Concepts

- Two eligibility pillars: (1) 35 contact hours of formal project management training, (2) professional project management experience leading projects.
- Experience requirement scales with education: bachelor's degree or higher = 36 months; associate degree/post-secondary diploma = 48 months; secondary diploma only = 60 months. All within the last 10 years.
- GAC (PMI Global Accreditation Center) accredited degree holders need only 24 months of experience — a shortened path recognizing built-in PM coursework.
- Experience must be recorded in months of leadership activity, not by number of projects; overlapping months across simultaneous projects are counted only once.
- Disqualified experience: academic coursework, personal life events (e.g., weddings), home renovations, and routine operational/administrative work.
- CAPM holders receive a training waiver — their CAPM certification satisfies the 35-hour training requirement automatically.
- PMI randomly audits some applications; being audited is a routine quality check, not evidence of a problem.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
35 contact hours	The minimum formal project management education required of all PMP candidates who do not already hold the CAPM certification.
GAC-accredited program	A university degree program in project management specifically accredited by PMI's Global Accreditation Center; graduates qualify with only 24 months of experience.
CAPM	Certified Associate in Project Management — an entry-level PMI credential; holding it waives the PMP's 35-hour training requirement.

PMI Audit	PMI's random verification process that checks supporting documentation (certificates, supervisor confirmation) for a sampled percentage of PMP applications.
10-year window	The rule that all claimed project leadership experience must have occurred within the ten years preceding the application.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. Memorize the three experience tiers by education level (36 / 48 / 60 months) — this is a frequently tested, easily scored fact.
2. Remember overlapping project months are counted once, not twice — a classic exam trap involving concurrent projects.
3. If a scenario mentions a CAPM holder applying for the PMP, recall the training-hour waiver immediately.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What are the two pillars of PMP eligibility, and how does the experience requirement change with education level?
2. How should a candidate handle two overlapping projects when calculating total months of experience?
3. What benefit does holding a CAPM certification provide toward PMP eligibility?

The PMP Exam Structure 2026: Domains, Weights, and Question Types

Overview

With eligibility explained, this lecture turns to the exam itself: how it is organized, how long it takes, and what kinds of questions to expect. The 2026 PMP exam tests scenario-based judgment across three weighted domains rather than rote recall, and it blends traditional, case-based, and interactive question formats.

Knowing the exact structure — domain weights, question count, timing, and break rules — lets you build a study plan that allocates effort proportionally and lets you manage the clock confidently on exam day.

Key Concepts

- Three exam domains and their weights: People 33%, Process 41%, Business Environment 26%.
- Process carries the largest share because it covers the many practical tasks of planning, executing, monitoring, and delivering work.
- Roughly 40% of questions center on predictive methods; the remaining 60% cover adaptive/agile and hybrid approaches, woven across all three domains.
- 180 total questions: 170 scored, 10 unscored pretest items indistinguishable from scored questions — treat every question as if it counts.
- Exam duration: 240 minutes (4 hours), with two optional 10-minute breaks; once you submit answers before a break you cannot revisit those questions.
- Traditional formats: multiple-choice single response and multiple-response.
- Modern formats: case/scenario-based question sets, matching, enhanced matching (drag-and-position), graphic-based, and point-and-click questions.
- Delivery channels: in-person computer-based testing (Pearson VUE, occasionally paper-based) or online proctored testing from an approved location.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
ECO Domain Weighting	The percentage of exam questions assigned to each of the three domains: People 33%, Process 41%, Business Environment 26%.
Pretest question	One of 10 unscored questions PMI embeds in the exam to evaluate future items; indistinguishable from the 170 scored questions.
Case-based question	A question format that presents a detailed project scenario, sometimes with charts or data, followed by several related questions.
Enhanced matching	An interactive question format requiring candidates to drag items into correct positions on a chart or diagram.
Online proctored testing	A remote PMP exam delivery option that uses identity verification and live monitoring in place of an in-person test center.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. Memorize the domain weights cold: People 33 / Process 41 / Business Environment 26 — these numbers are foundational to study-time allocation.

2. Remember 180 questions in 240 minutes with 170 scored — do not waste time trying to guess which 10 are pretest items.
3. Because you cannot return to questions once you take a break, always review your current block of answers before choosing to break.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. List the three PMP exam domains with their approximate percentage weightings.
2. How many total questions are on the exam, how many are scored, and how long do candidates have to complete it?
3. Name at least three PMP question formats beyond standard multiple-choice.

PMBOK 8 vs PMBOK 7: Key Changes and Paradigm Shifts

Overview

This lecture compares the 7th and 8th editions of the PMBOK Guide, since the PMP exam is expected to begin reflecting PMBOK 8 content around July 2026. PMBOK 8 partially returns to a process-oriented structure reminiscent of PMBOK 6 while keeping the principle- and performance-driven thinking introduced in PMBOK 7.

Beyond restructuring, PMBOK 8 renames core terminology, folds some knowledge areas into broader concepts, reduces the total process count, and adds new content on artificial intelligence — while the underlying philosophy of planning, executing, monitoring, and closing work stays constant across editions.

Key Concepts

- PMBOK 8 blends PMBOK 7's principle/performance-domain thinking with a renewed, more structured process model reminiscent of PMBOK 6.
- Terminology shift: Process Groups is trending toward Focus Groups; Knowledge Areas is reframed as Performance Domains.
- Project Integration is broadened into Governance, reflecting a stronger emphasis on oversight and strategic alignment.
- Communications is folded into the Stakeholders domain, reflecting that communication and stakeholder management are inseparable in practice.
- Procurement Management is streamlined into a core process, Plan Sourcing Strategy.
- Quality is no longer a standalone knowledge area — quality considerations are now embedded directly into other processes and activities.
- PMBOK 8 introduces a new appendix on Artificial Intelligence (including GPT-style tools) and how AI supports data analysis, risk prediction, and reporting.

- Total process count drops from 49 (PMBOK 6) to 40 in PMBOK 8, aimed at simplifying the framework.
- Despite structural change, the core philosophy — plan, execute, monitor, close — is unchanged across every PMBOK edition.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Focus Groups	PMBOK 8's proposed evolution of the term 'Process Groups,' emphasizing areas of concentrated project manager effort.
Performance Domains	PMBOK 8's reframing of 'Knowledge Areas' around outcomes and capabilities a project must achieve, rather than static topic areas.
Governance (PMBOK 8)	The broadened successor concept to Project Integration Management, emphasizing oversight, accountability, and strategic alignment.
Plan Sourcing Strategy	The streamlined core process replacing the more detailed Procurement Management knowledge area of earlier editions.
40 processes	The total number of processes in PMBOK 8, down from 49 in PMBOK 6, reflecting an intentional simplification of the framework.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. If a question references 'Focus Groups' or 'Performance Domains,' recognize these as PMBOK 8's renamed successors to Process Groups and Knowledge Areas.
2. Know that Communications merges into Stakeholders and Quality is no longer standalone — both are common terminology-mapping traps.
3. The AI appendix in PMBOK 8 is about the impact of AI on PM practice, not a technical AI curriculum — expect conceptual, not technical, questions.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What structural shift characterizes PMBOK 8 relative to PMBOK 7, and which earlier edition does it partly resemble?
2. Name two knowledge areas that have been folded into broader concepts in PMBOK

8, and describe the new concept for each.
3. How many processes does PMBOK 8 define, compared to PMBOK 6?

The Project Management Mindset: A New Focus in PMBOK 8

Overview

PMBOK 8 treats project management as more than a checklist of processes — it defines a mindset built on principles and value creation. This lecture introduces that mindset through six interlocking ideas: stewardship, systems thinking, value delivery, adaptability, collaboration over heroics, and ethical reasoning.

The exam increasingly rewards this mindset directly: scenario questions ask what an experienced, principled project manager would do, not just what a textbook process says to do next.

Key Concepts

- PMBOK 8 shifts emphasis from process-centric execution to a principle-based mindset that guides judgment across changing situations.
- Stewardship: managing resources, stakeholder trust, and organizational goals responsibly and ethically, not just exercising authority.
- Systems thinking: recognizing that a project sits inside a larger organizational and environmental system, and that decisions ripple outward.
- Value delivery mindset: continuously asking whether project activities are producing outcomes that truly matter, not just meeting scope/schedule/cost targets.
- Adaptability as a core competency: building feedback loops and adjusting plans as conditions change, rather than resisting change.
- Collaboration over heroics: sustainable success comes from team empowerment and psychological safety, not a single heroic leader.
- Embracing complexity and ambiguity: treating uncertainty as an opportunity for innovative solutions rather than a problem to eliminate.
- Ethical reasoning: honesty, transparency, and fairness underpin every project decision and build stakeholder trust.
- Exam relevance: scenario questions increasingly test professional judgment shaped by this mindset, not memorized definitions.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Stewardship	A PMBOK 8 principle describing responsible, ethical management of resources and stakeholder trust on behalf of the organization and its people.
Systems thinking	The practice of viewing a project as part of an

	interconnected organizational and environmental system rather than an isolated effort.
Value delivery mindset	A decision-making lens that continuously asks whether project work is producing outcomes that matter, beyond simply hitting scope/schedule/cost targets.
Psychological safety	A team condition in which members feel safe to share ideas, raise concerns, and take interpersonal risks without fear of punishment.
Ethical reasoning	Decision-making grounded in honesty, transparency, and fairness, including a willingness to raise concerns about questionable practices.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. When an exam scenario gives you a values conflict (e.g., pressure to hide a problem), the mindset-aligned answer favors honesty and stakeholder trust over short-term convenience.
2. 'Collaboration over heroics' is a strong signal for exam answers that favor empowering the team over a PM personally solving every problem.
3. Expect systems-thinking questions to ask about downstream effects of a decision beyond the immediate project.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Name the six mindset elements introduced in this lecture and briefly define stewardship.
2. How does the value delivery mindset differ from a pure focus on scope, schedule, and cost?
3. Why does PMBOK 8 favor collaboration over individual heroics as a leadership model?

Understanding Business Value: Tangible vs. Intangible

Overview

Every project exists to create value, and PMBOK 8 insists this question be answered before detailed planning begins. This lecture distinguishes tangible value (revenue, cost savings, market share — all directly measurable) from intangible value (brand perception, employee morale, customer trust — real but harder to quantify).

The lecture also draws a critical distinction between deliverables and value: completing an output on time and budget does not automatically mean the project succeeded if that output fails to generate the intended benefit.

Key Concepts

- Business value is the measurable benefit an organization expects from a project, typically documented in the business case.
- Tangible value: directly measurable financial or market outcomes — increased revenue, cost reduction, expanded market share, competitive positioning.
- Intangible value: brand perception, employee morale/retention, and customer trust — real but not directly reflected on financial statements.
- Both types of value matter; overweighting tangible value while damaging morale or trust can undermine long-term success, and vice versa.
- Intangible value can still be tracked using proxy indicators: engagement surveys, retention rates, customer satisfaction scores, Net Promoter Score, brand recognition studies.
- Deliverables vs. value: a completed, on-time, on-budget deliverable that nobody uses or that fails to solve the intended problem has not delivered value.
- Value conversations begin at project initiation — before the charter is finalized, stakeholders must agree on the value the project is meant to create.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Business value	The measurable benefit — financial, operational, or strategic — an organization expects to receive from undertaking a project.
Tangible value	Benefits that can be directly measured in financial or market terms, such as revenue growth, cost savings, or market share gains.
Intangible value	Real but not directly quantifiable benefits, such as brand perception, employee morale, and customer trust.
Net Promoter Score (NPS)	A customer loyalty metric used as a proxy indicator for intangible value such as customer trust and satisfaction.

Business case	The document that justifies undertaking a project by describing its expected tangible and intangible value, costs, and risks.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. If an exam option treats 'completing the deliverable' as automatically equal to 'delivering value,' be suspicious — PMBOK 8 explicitly separates the two.
2. Remember concrete examples of intangible value proxies (engagement surveys, NPS, retention rate) — exam scenarios often describe the proxy without naming the underlying value type.
3. A project that hits scope/schedule/cost but damages morale or trust is not automatically a PMP-exam 'success' — value alignment matters more than mechanical completion.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Give two examples each of tangible and intangible value.
2. Why can a project be completed on time and budget and still fail to deliver value?
3. How can organizations measure benefits, like employee morale, that are not directly financial?

Introduction to the Value Delivery System

Overview

This lecture zooms out from a single project to PMBOK 8's Value Delivery System — the ecosystem connecting organizational strategy, portfolios, programs, projects, and operations in a continuous cycle of value creation. Understanding this system changes how you see your own project: not as an isolated effort, but as one contributing piece of the organization's mission.

The lecture also covers governance's role in keeping the system aligned, how value flows through each layer, and how change management bridges project completion and sustained operational use.

Key Concepts

- The Value Delivery System connects four components: organizational strategy, portfolios, programs/projects, and operations, in a continuous cycle.

- Strategy sets long-term direction; portfolios select the initiatives that support it; programs coordinate related projects; projects deliver specific outputs; operations sustain and run those outputs.
- Governance establishes decision rights, priorities, and escalation paths that keep the whole system aligned and functioning.
- Value flows continuously: strategy → portfolio selection → program/project delivery → operational use → feedback that refines future strategy.
- Change management bridges the gap between project completion and sustained operational adoption — without it, deliverables may go unused.
- The system works in both predictive environments (value at defined milestones) and agile environments (value delivered iteratively through sprints).
- Common breakdowns: poor project-to-operations handoff, unclear governance, portfolios drifting from strategy, and programs failing to coordinate their projects.
- Project managers should communicate beyond their immediate team — with portfolio leaders, program managers, and operations — to support the wider system.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Value Delivery System	PMBOK 8's model of the interconnected ecosystem — strategy, portfolios, programs, projects, and operations — through which organizations create and sustain value.
Governance (system-level)	The rules, structures, and decision rights that keep portfolios, programs, and projects aligned with organizational strategy.
Change management	The discipline of preparing people to adopt new systems or processes, bridging the gap between project delivery and operational use.
Feedback loop	The continuous flow of lessons learned and performance data from operations and completed projects back into strategic planning.
Sprint (value delivery context)	A short, fixed-length iteration in agile environments through which incremental value is delivered and refined.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. Exam scenarios that ask about a project's connection to strategy are testing your grasp of the Value Delivery System — trace the chain: strategy → portfolio → program

→ project.
2. If a scenario describes a completed project whose benefits are not being realized, suspect a breakdown in the project-to-operations transition or weak change management.
3. Remember governance operates at the system level (keeping portfolios/programs/projects aligned to strategy), distinct from project-level governance covered later in the section.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Name the four components of the Value Delivery System and explain how they connect.
2. What role does governance play in the Value Delivery System?
3. Why is change management essential to realizing value after a project is delivered?

The Project Manager's Role: Competencies and Responsibilities

Overview

This lecture defines the modern project manager as a servant leader who balances process responsibilities (scope, schedule, budget, change control) with people responsibilities (stakeholders, conflict, communication, team leadership), guided by PMI's Talent Triangle.

It also frames the project manager as the bridge between the project team and the business environment — translating strategic goals into deliverables and reporting status back up to leadership.

Key Concepts

- Servant leadership: the PMBOK 8 leadership model, especially prominent in agile/hybrid environments, prioritizing team growth and well-being over command-and-control.
- PMI Talent Triangle — three competency areas: Ways of Working (technical skills across predictive, agile, hybrid), Power Skills (leadership, communication, collaboration), and Business Acumen (linking outcomes to strategy and value).
- Process responsibilities: developing the project management plan, managing scope/schedule/budget, and controlling changes.
- People responsibilities: managing stakeholders, resolving conflict, leading the team, ensuring effective communication.

- Exam scenarios frequently require balancing process and people responsibilities, with a bias toward prioritizing people/stakeholder concerns when the two conflict.
- The project manager acts as a translator and bridge — converting strategic goals into deliverables and reporting progress back to executive stakeholders.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Servant leadership	A leadership style that prioritizes the growth, needs, and well-being of the team over command-and-control authority.
PMI Talent Triangle	PMI's model of three core PM competency areas: Ways of Working, Power Skills, and Business Acumen.
Ways of Working	The Talent Triangle competency covering technical project management skills across predictive, agile, and hybrid approaches.
Power Skills	The Talent Triangle competency covering leadership, communication, and collaboration abilities.
Business Acumen	The Talent Triangle competency covering the ability to connect project outcomes to organizational strategy and value.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. When a PMP scenario forces a trade-off between a process task and a people issue (e.g., a schedule slip vs. a team conflict), the people/relationship-preserving answer is usually favored.
2. Memorize the three sides of the Talent Triangle by name — questions sometimes ask which side a described skill belongs to.
3. Servant leadership language ('remove impediments,' 'empower the team') signals the exam's preferred leadership style — avoid answers describing top-down command.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What are the three sides of the PMI Talent Triangle?
2. How does servant leadership differ from traditional command-and-control

leadership?
3. Give one example each of a process responsibility and a people responsibility for a project manager.

Project, Program, and Portfolio Management: Understanding the Hierarchy

Overview

This lecture builds the vocabulary and hierarchy needed for the Business Environment domain: projects deliver specific outputs, programs coordinate related projects to capture benefits no single project could achieve alone, and portfolios group initiatives — related or not — to advance organizational strategy.

Concrete examples (a mobile banking app as a project, an EV launch as a program, a diversified tech company's initiatives as a portfolio) anchor the abstract definitions in recognizable business situations.

Key Concepts

- Project: a temporary effort with a defined start and finish that creates a unique product, service, or result (e.g., building a mobile banking app).
- Program: a group of related projects managed together to realize benefits unavailable if managed individually (e.g., an EV launch spanning battery, design, manufacturing, and marketing projects).
- Portfolio: a collection of projects, programs, and sometimes operations, managed together to achieve strategic objectives — the components need not be related to each other.
- Hierarchy: projects → programs → portfolios → organizational strategy, connecting daily work to long-term business direction.
- Simple memory device: projects deliver outputs, programs deliver benefits, portfolios deliver strategic value.
- Organizations adopt this structure to prioritize investments, allocate resources efficiently, and avoid duplicated effort across many simultaneous initiatives.
- A project manager's day-to-day focus is the individual project, but decisions at the program or portfolio level can reshape that project's priorities, budget, or timeline.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Project	A temporary endeavor with a defined start and end, undertaken to create a unique product, service, or result.
Program	A group of related projects, subsidiary programs, and program activities managed

	together to obtain benefits not available from managing them individually.
Portfolio	Projects, programs, and operations managed as a group to achieve strategic business objectives; components need not be interdependent.
Program benefits	The additional value achieved by coordinating related projects together that would not be realized if each project were managed in isolation.
Strategic alignment	The degree to which a portfolio's selected initiatives support the organization's long-term goals.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. Use the memory phrase 'projects deliver outputs, programs deliver benefits, portfolios deliver strategic value' to answer classification questions quickly.
2. A key differentiator: program components ARE related; portfolio components need NOT be related — only aligned to strategy.
3. If a scenario describes unrelated initiatives grouped for strategic prioritization, that is a portfolio, not a program — a common exam distractor.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Define project, program, and portfolio, and explain how they form a hierarchy.
2. What is the key difference between how projects are grouped in a program versus a portfolio?
3. Why do organizations use this three-level structure instead of managing every initiative independently?

The Relationship Between Portfolios, Programs, Projects, and Operations

Overview

Building on the previous lecture, this one adds operations as the fourth essential element and focuses on how all four pieces connect end to end — from strategy at the

top, through portfolio selection and program coordination, down to individual projects, with operations running alongside to sustain results.

Special attention goes to the project-to-operations handoff, resource sharing between project and operational work, and the role of the PMO in supporting the whole structure.

Key Concepts

- Organizations perform two kinds of work: temporary (projects) and ongoing (operations); both are essential and interdependent.
- Structure top-down: organizational strategy → portfolio (selected initiatives) → programs (coordinated project groups) → individual projects, with operations running alongside to sustain outputs.
- Difference between projects and operations: projects are temporary and change-focused; operations are ongoing and stability/efficiency-focused.
- Project-to-operations handoff is a critical risk point — inadequate training or documentation at handoff can undermine an otherwise successful project.
- Resource sharing: the same employees often support both operations and projects, creating tension between continuous operational demands and fixed project deadlines that requires clear resource-sharing rules.
- Portfolio managers prioritize among competing project ideas based on strategic importance, expected value, and risk, since resources are always limited.
- The PMO (Project Management Office) supports the whole structure with standards, prioritization support, performance monitoring, tools, and training.
- Lessons learned flow from completed projects/programs back into the strategy layer, creating a continuous improvement cycle.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Operations	Ongoing, repetitive organizational activities (e.g., customer support, manufacturing, IT maintenance) that have no defined end date and focus on stability.
Handoff	The transition point at which a completed project deliverable is transferred to an operations team for ongoing management and support.
PMO	Project Management Office — an organizational function that sets standards, supports prioritization, monitors performance, and provides tools/training for projects and programs.
Resource-sharing rules	Organizational policies that balance the competing demands of continuous operational

	work and fixed-deadline project work on shared staff.
Lessons learned	Documented insights from completed projects and programs, fed back into organizational strategy and future initiative planning.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. When a scenario describes a poorly planned handoff (e.g., untrained support staff, undocumented procedures), the exam-favored answer involves better transition planning, not blaming operations.
2. Remember operations teams should be engaged before a project ends, not after — proactive involvement prevents handoff failure.
3. The PMO's role spans standards, prioritization, and support — treat it as an enabler, not a bottleneck, in exam scenarios.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. How do operations differ from projects, and why do organizations need both?
2. What can go wrong during the project-to-operations handoff, and how can it be prevented?
3. What functions does a PMO typically provide to support this overall structure?

Organizational Structures: Functional, Matrix, and Projectized

Overview

Organizational structure determines how much authority a project manager actually has — a recurring theme on the PMP exam. This lecture walks the full spectrum from functional (project manager as coordinator, functional managers hold authority and resources) to projectized (project manager holds full authority and a dedicated team), with the three matrix variants — weak, balanced, and strong — in between.

Special attention is given to the 'two bosses' dynamic inherent to any matrix structure, since exam scenarios frequently test how a project manager should navigate competing direction from a functional manager and a project manager.

Key Concepts

- Functional organization: employees grouped by department (engineering, marketing, etc.); project manager has low authority; team reports primarily to functional managers.
- Projectized organization: structured around projects; project manager has high authority and a dedicated, fully assigned team; strong speed and coordination, but less job stability once the project ends.
- Matrix organization: blends functional and projectized characteristics; employees may report to both a functional manager and a project manager.
- Weak matrix: functional manager holds most authority; project manager acts largely as coordinator/facilitator and must negotiate for resources.
- Balanced matrix: authority is shared between functional and project managers, requiring strong mutual communication and collaboration.
- Strong matrix: project manager holds more authority than the functional manager over project decisions, resources, and priorities.
- 'Two bosses' situation: in any matrix, employees answer to both a functional manager (career development, technical expertise) and a project manager (project tasks, deadlines) — clear role definition and communication prevent conflicting instructions.
- Structure directly shapes PM authority and leadership approach: low-authority environments require negotiation and influence; high-authority environments allow faster direct decision-making.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Functional organization	A structure where staff are grouped by department and the project manager has limited authority relative to functional managers.
Projectized organization	A structure built primarily around projects, giving the project manager high authority and a dedicated project team.
Weak matrix	A matrix structure in which the functional manager retains most authority and the project manager functions mainly as a coordinator.
Balanced matrix	A matrix structure in which authority is shared roughly equally between the functional manager and the project manager.
Strong matrix	A matrix structure in which the project manager holds more authority than the functional manager over project decisions and resources.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. Build a mental authority ladder from lowest to highest PM authority: Functional → Weak Matrix → Balanced Matrix → Strong Matrix → Projectized — many questions simply ask you to rank or identify a point on this ladder.
2. The 'two bosses' concept is a favorite exam theme — expect scenarios about conflicting priorities from a functional manager and a project manager in a matrix structure.
3. In functional and weak-matrix scenarios, the best PM response usually involves negotiation and relationship-building rather than direct command.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Rank the five organizational structures discussed by increasing project manager authority.
2. What is the 'two bosses' situation, and why can it create confusion for team members?
3. What distinguishes a strong matrix from a projectized organization?

Project Life Cycles: Predictive, Iterative, Incremental, and Agile

Overview

This lecture introduces the four foundational project life cycles that shape how work is planned and delivered: predictive (plan everything up front, deliver at the end), iterative (repeatedly refine the product), incremental (deliver usable pieces progressively), and agile (a blend of iterative and incremental delivered in short sprints).

Choosing the right life cycle is a tailoring decision driven by how clear requirements are and how much change is expected — a theme that recurs throughout the course and is central to the PMP's modern, adaptability-focused philosophy.

Key Concepts

- Project life cycle: the sequence of phases a project moves through from start to finish, structuring how work is planned, executed, and delivered.
- Predictive (waterfall): scope, schedule, and budget defined up front; sequential phases; best when requirements are stable (construction, manufacturing, infrastructure).

- Iterative: the team builds a basic version and refines it through repeated cycles, using feedback to converge on the correct solution.
- Incremental: the product is delivered in small, complete, usable pieces (increments) over time, letting stakeholders gain value earlier and provide feedback sooner.
- Agile: combines iterative and incremental development in short, fixed-length cycles (sprints, typically 2-4 weeks); emphasizes collaboration, continuous feedback, and rapid response to change.
- Comparison shorthand: predictive plans then delivers; iterative refines the solution; incremental delivers usable pieces progressively; agile combines refinement and progressive delivery with high adaptability.
- The best life cycle depends on requirement clarity, project complexity, and the level of uncertainty involved — not a universal 'best' method.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Predictive life cycle	A traditional, plan-driven approach (also called waterfall) where scope, schedule, and budget are defined early and followed sequentially.
Iterative life cycle	An approach where the team develops a basic version of the product and repeatedly refines it based on feedback.
Incremental life cycle	An approach where the product is delivered in small, complete, usable portions (increments) over the course of the project.
Agile life cycle	An approach combining iterative and incremental development delivered through short, fixed-length cycles called sprints.
Sprint	A short, fixed-length development cycle (commonly 2-4 weeks) in agile life cycles during which a working product increment is planned, built, and delivered.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. Don't confuse iterative (refining the SAME evolving product) with incremental (delivering separate, complete usable PIECES) — this distinction is a classic exam trap.
2. Agile = iterative + incremental, delivered in sprints — remembering this formula resolves most life-cycle classification questions instantly.
3. Predictive life cycles suit stable, well-understood requirements (construction,

regulated systems); agile suits uncertain, evolving requirements (innovative software).

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What is the key difference between an iterative life cycle and an incremental life cycle?
2. Describe the agile life cycle in terms of the other three life cycles.
3. What factors should drive the choice of project life cycle?

Hybrid Approaches: Combining Predictive and Adaptive Elements

Overview

Real projects rarely use a single life cycle from start to finish. This lecture explains the hybrid life cycle — combining predictive methods for stable, well-defined components with agile methods for uncertain, evolving ones — and why hybrid has become the most common real-world approach.

It also covers the mechanics of making hybrid work: tailoring the blend to context, integrating predictive and agile workstreams, and managing communication and change across teams that may be operating on different rhythms.

Key Concepts

- Hybrid life cycle: a deliberate combination of predictive and adaptive approaches within a single project, applying each where it fits best.
- Common hybrid models: predictive planning/design phase followed by agile development/testing; or predictive overall schedule with agile delivery of specific components.
- Tailoring drives the blend: requirement clarity, complexity, stakeholder expectations, and uncertainty determine how much of each approach to use (PMBOK principle: Tailor for Context).
- Integration challenge: different teams may run on different processes/timelines; synchronization meetings and regular reviews keep predictive and agile workstreams aligned.
- Communication and change management matter more in hybrid projects because agile teams (evolving backlogs) and predictive teams (fixed plans) need a unified change process.
- Benefits: structure and stability where needed, flexibility and adaptation where needed, earlier value delivery, and better fit for complex projects with mixed technical and operational constraints.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Hybrid life cycle	A project life cycle that deliberately combines predictive and adaptive (agile) elements to fit different parts of the same project.
Tailoring	The PMBOK 8 practice of adapting the project management approach — including life cycle choice — to the specific context of the project.
Synchronization meeting	A recurring checkpoint used in hybrid projects to align predictive and agile workstreams operating on different rhythms.
Unified change management process	A single, coordinated process for handling both formally planned scope changes and evolving agile backlog items.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. Hybrid is not a fixed formula — it is a tailored blend, so exam answers describing a hybrid approach should reference adapting to project-specific context, not a single fixed pattern.
2. A common hybrid pattern worth memorizing: predictive planning/architecture up front, agile sprints for development/testing.
3. If a scenario describes strong communication friction between agile and predictive sub-teams, expect the correct answer to involve synchronization meetings or a unified change process.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What is a hybrid life cycle, and why have hybrid approaches become common in modern projects?
2. Give an example of a common hybrid model combining predictive and agile phases.
3. Why is communication especially important to manage well in hybrid projects?

Organizational Governance vs. Project Governance

Overview

Governance defines how decisions get made and who is accountable for them. This lecture distinguishes organizational governance (strategic-level rules set by senior leadership and the board) from project governance (the framework of sponsors, steering committees, and stakeholders that guides decisions within a specific project), and explains how the two levels connect.

It also covers governance frameworks, how governance adapts in agile environments, escalation paths, the PMO's supporting role, and the consequences of weak governance — all frequent PMP exam themes.

Key Concepts

- Governance answers who has authority to decide, how decisions are evaluated, what rules apply, and who is accountable.
- Organizational governance operates at the strategic, company-wide level — set by senior leadership and the board, defining mission, priorities, and resource allocation.
- Project governance operates at the project level — sponsor, steering committee, and key stakeholders reviewing progress and approving major project decisions.
- The two levels are connected: organizational policy shapes project decisions, and project-level issues can escalate up to influence organizational strategy.
- The project manager's governance role: follow organizational policy, escalate issues beyond their authority, and implement project governance processes (change control, reporting, stakeholder communication).
- Formal governance frameworks (e.g., COBIT, ISO 38500) define roles, responsibilities, and decision processes; PMBOK does not prescribe a specific framework but expects PMs to understand their organization's approach.
- Agile governance is more flexible than traditional stage-gate governance — frequent stakeholder review and feedback replace large phase-gate approvals, while still preserving accountability.
- Escalation paths define what happens when an issue exceeds the project manager's authority (e.g., escalating to a sponsor or steering committee for extra funding or strategic approval).
- The PMO supports governance by setting standards, monitoring performance, and facilitating steering committee reporting.
- Weak or unclear governance leads to uncontrolled scope changes, unclear priorities, wasted resources, and hidden problems due to unclear escalation paths.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Organizational governance	The strategic-level system of policies and oversight, set by senior leadership and the board, that directs and controls the

	organization as a whole.
Project governance	The project-level framework — sponsor, steering committee, key stakeholders — that guides decisions on scope, schedule, budget, and risk for a specific project.
Escalation path	A defined process describing where and to whom an issue is raised when it exceeds the current decision-maker's authority.
Stage-gate model	A traditional governance approach where formal approvals occur at major project phase milestones.
COBIT / ISO 38500	Examples of formal external governance frameworks organizations may adopt to define roles, responsibilities, and decision-making processes.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. When a scenario asks 'who should make this decision,' first identify whether it is a strategic (organizational governance) or project-level (project governance) decision.
2. A clear escalation path is the exam-favored answer whenever a project manager faces an issue beyond their authority — escalate, don't decide unilaterally or ignore it.
3. In agile scenarios, expect governance described as frequent, lightweight stakeholder reviews rather than large formal stage-gate approvals.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. How does organizational governance differ from project governance, and how are the two connected?
2. What is an escalation path, and why is it important?
3. How does governance typically differ between traditional stage-gate and agile environments?

Factors for Project Initiation (Regulatory, Strategic, Social, etc.)

Overview

No project starts randomly — this lecture catalogs the drivers that cause organizations to initiate projects: strategic ambition, regulatory/compliance mandates, social and environmental expectations, technological opportunity, customer demand, and internal operational needs.

It also explains how the business case and feasibility assessment formalize the decision to proceed, how portfolio-level prioritization allocates limited resources among competing project ideas, and why project objectives should always trace back to the original initiation driver.

Key Concepts

- Strategic factors: entering new markets, launching innovative products, or building future capabilities (e.g., new data platforms) to stay competitive.
- Regulatory and compliance drivers: new laws or standards (environmental, safety, financial reporting, data privacy) that make a project mandatory, with penalties for non-compliance.
- Social and environmental factors: sustainability, community development, diversity and inclusion initiatives driven by stakeholder and societal expectations.
- Technological opportunities: emerging technologies (AI, cloud, automation, robotics) that create new possibilities, often requiring flexible, experimental project approaches.
- Customer demand: projects initiated directly in response to customer requests or expectations, often carrying urgency and strong stakeholder engagement.
- Internal operational needs: upgrading outdated systems or fixing inefficient processes to improve day-to-day organizational performance.
- Business case: documents the problem/opportunity, proposed solution, benefits, costs, timeline, and risks, and later serves as a reference point throughout the project.
- Feasibility assessment: evaluates whether a project is technically possible, financially affordable, and realistically achievable given available expertise and resources.
- Portfolio-level prioritization ranks competing project ideas by strategic importance, expected benefit, risk, and resource availability.
- Project objectives should align with the original initiation driver — e.g., compliance becomes the primary success criterion for a regulatory-driven project.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Business case	The document justifying a project by describing

	the problem/opportunity, proposed solution, expected benefits, costs, timeline, and risks.
Feasibility assessment	An evaluation of whether a proposed project is technically possible, financially affordable, and realistically achievable.
Compliance-driven project	A project initiated primarily to meet new regulatory or legal requirements, where the main success criterion is meeting the compliance standard.
Portfolio prioritization	The process of ranking and selecting among competing project ideas based on strategic importance, value, risk, and available resources.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. When a scenario names the reason a project was launched, match the project's success criteria to that same driver — e.g., compliance projects are judged on meeting the regulation, not on ROI alone.
2. Regulatory/compliance projects are typically non-discretionary — recognize language like 'must comply' as signaling this category over strategic or customer-demand drivers.
3. Remember the business case and feasibility assessment are separate but related: the business case argues why to do the project; feasibility assesses whether it can realistically be done.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. List at least four different categories of factors that can initiate a project.
2. What is the difference between a business case and a feasibility assessment?
3. Why should project objectives align with the original reason the project was initiated?

Where Operations and Project Management Intersect

Overview

This lecture deepens the projects-vs-operations theme with a practical focus on the friction points where the two intersect: the handoff of a project deliverable into

operations, resource sharing between operational staff and project work, and sustaining benefits after a project formally closes.

It positions operational readiness as a project deliverable in its own right — a technically complete solution that operations cannot support is not a truly successful project.

Key Concepts

- Projects focus on change and innovation with a defined start/end; operations focus on efficiency and stability with no end date — but the two must work together closely.
- The transition to operations is one of the most critical, failure-prone stages of a project; inadequate preparation causes untrained staff, unclear procedures, and poor support.
- Project execution can disrupt ongoing operations (design reviews, testing, training) because operational staff are pulled into project activities alongside their daily responsibilities.
- Shared resources (the same employees supporting both operations and projects) require clear resource-sharing rules to balance continuous operational demand against project deadlines.
- Change management is the bridge between project delivery and operational adoption: training, addressing resistance, and communicating benefits.
- Operational readiness — trained staff, documented procedures, tested support processes — should be treated as a project deliverable, not an afterthought.
- Benefits realization continues after project closeout: the PM and stakeholders should verify that expected improvements (e.g., productivity gains) are actually being achieved in operations.
- At closeout, the project manager confirms documentation is complete, training has occurred, and support systems are in place before formally closing the project.
- PMP exam scenarios frequently test whether a described task is 'project' or 'operational' work, and how to resolve resource conflicts between the two.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Operational readiness	The state of an operations team being fully prepared — trained, documented, tested — to manage a project deliverable; treated as a project deliverable itself.
Benefits realization	The ongoing process of verifying, after project closeout, that the expected benefits of a project are actually being achieved in operations.
Change management (bridge role)	The discipline of preparing people to adopt a new system or process, connecting project delivery to sustained operational use.

Resource-sharing conflict	The tension that arises when the same staff must support both continuous operational work and fixed-deadline project work.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. If a scenario shows a technically complete project failing to succeed post-launch, look for a gap in operational readiness or change management, not a technical flaw.
2. Treat 'operational readiness' as its own checklist item (training, documentation, tested support) worth naming explicitly on the exam.
3. When resource conflicts arise between operations and a project, the PM's role is coordination and negotiation to minimize disruption — not simply pulling staff off operational duties.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Why is the transition from project to operations considered one of the most critical project stages?
2. What does 'operational readiness' include, and why should it be treated as a project deliverable?
3. How should a project manager handle resource conflicts between operations and project work?

Section 1 Summary and Knowledge Check

Overview

This closing lecture consolidates Section 1 into four themes: PMP fundamentals (eligibility, the 2026 exam structure, and the PMBOK 7-to-8 shift), project context (the project/program/portfolio hierarchy, organizational structures, and the four life cycles plus hybrid), governance and initiation (why and how projects start, and how they are governed), and the project manager mindset (servant leadership, adaptability, and value-focused thinking).

It ends with a short self-check before advancing to Section 2's deep dive into the six core principles of PMBOK 8, beginning with Adopt a Holistic View.

Key Concepts

- PMP fundamentals recap: 35 contact hours + experience requirement, the 180-question / 240-minute exam with domain weights People 33% / Process 41% /

Business Environment 26%, and the PMBOK 7-to-8 shift toward principles, performance domains, and digital integration.

- Project context recap: the project → program → portfolio hierarchy, the five organizational structures from functional to projectized, and the four life cycles (predictive, iterative, incremental, agile) plus hybrid blends.
- Governance and initiation recap: organizational vs. project governance, escalation paths, and the strategic/regulatory/social/technological/customer/operational drivers behind project initiation.
- Project manager mindset recap: servant leadership balancing process and people responsibilities, adaptability and value delivery over rigid plan-following, and the PM as the bridge between team and business environment.
- Section 1 self-check prompts: name the three exam domains and weights; list at least three of the six PMBOK 8 core principles; explain the difference between a program and a portfolio.
- Readiness gate: if these self-check questions feel uncertain, revisit the relevant lecture before moving to Section 2.

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition
Section 1 readiness gate	The self-check at the end of Section 1 confirming a learner can recall exam structure, PMBOK 7-to-8 changes, and the project/program/portfolio hierarchy before advancing.
PMBOK 8 core principles	The six guiding principles covered in Section 2, beginning with Adopt a Holistic View, that anchor the rest of the course.

Exam Tips

✦ EXAM TIPS

1. Use this summary lecture as a self-test: if you cannot immediately state the three domain weights and the project/program/portfolio distinction from memory, revisit those specific lectures before Section 2.
2. Section 1 is foundational vocabulary for the entire exam — expect terms and structures introduced here (governance, life cycles, organizational structures, value) to reappear inside Section 2 through Section 11 scenario questions.

Knowledge Check

✦ KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Name the three domains of the PMP exam and their approximate weightings.
2. List at least three of the six core principles of the PMBOK 8th Edition (to be covered fully in Section 2).
3. Explain the difference between a program and a portfolio.

Appendix

A. Section 1 Quick Reference

Use this as your mental model whenever you need to recall the foundational facts and structures introduced in Section 1.

- PMP eligibility: 35 contact hours of training + 24-60 months of project leadership experience (varies by education level), all within the last 10 years.
- 2026 exam blueprint: 180 questions (170 scored, 10 pretest), 240 minutes, two optional 10-minute breaks.
- Domain weights: People 33% | Process 41% | Business Environment 26%.
- Approach mix: roughly 40% predictive, 60% adaptive/agile and hybrid, woven across all three domains.
- Hierarchy: Organizational Strategy -> Portfolio -> Program -> Project, with Operations sustaining outputs alongside.
- PM authority ladder (low to high): Functional -> Weak Matrix -> Balanced Matrix -> Strong Matrix -> Projectized.
- Four life cycles: Predictive (plan then deliver), Iterative (refine the same product), Incremental (deliver usable pieces), Agile (iterative + incremental in sprints); Hybrid blends them.

B. Organizational Structure Authority Comparison

Structure	Project Manager Authority
Functional	Low — PM acts as coordinator; functional manager controls resources and team.
Weak Matrix	Low-to-moderate — PM negotiates for resources; functional manager retains most authority.
Balanced Matrix	Moderate — authority shared between functional manager and project manager.
Strong Matrix	Moderate-to-high — PM has more authority than the functional manager over project decisions.
Projectized	High — PM has full authority over a dedicated,

	fully assigned project team.

C. Section 1 Study Checklist

Use this checklist to confirm you have mastered each foundational topic before moving to Section 2. Beware treating any single item as optional — exam scenarios routinely combine two or three of these topics in one question.

- Confirm eligibility: 35 training hours (or CAPM waiver) + correct experience tier for your education level.
- Know the 2026 exam blueprint cold: 180 questions, 240 minutes, domain weights 33/41/26.
- Be able to explain at least three PMBOK 7-to-8 terminology or structural changes.
- Distinguish project, program, and portfolio with an example of each.
- Rank the five organizational structures by project manager authority.
- Differentiate the four life cycles (predictive, iterative, incremental, agile) and describe hybrid.
- Explain the difference between organizational governance and project governance, and what an escalation path is.
- List at least four categories of project initiation drivers.
- Describe what 'operational readiness' means and why it belongs on the project's deliverable list.
- Articulate the project manager mindset: servant leadership, value delivery, adaptability, and stewardship.

D. Exam Cheat Sheet

✦ EXAM CHEAT SHEET

1. If a question tests domain weighting, recall People 33 / Process 41 / Business Environment 26 immediately.
2. If a question describes unrelated initiatives grouped for strategic prioritization, that's a portfolio; if it describes related, coordinated projects, that's a program.
3. If a question asks who should decide something, separate strategic (organizational governance) from project-level (project governance) decisions before choosing an answer.
4. If a scenario shows a completed, on-budget deliverable that nobody uses, suspect a value or operational-readiness gap rather than a technical failure.
5. If a scenario centers on conflicting instructions from two managers, recognize the matrix organization's 'two bosses' dynamic and favor clear communication/negotiation answers.
6. Match project success criteria to the original initiation driver named in the scenario (compliance, strategy, customer demand, etc.).